

that has quite worked out.

The other piece in the story is that of bilateral ODIs. That will weaken considerably and the game could easily reduce to a once-in-four-years festival.

I will be very pleased to see non-cricket sports take off. However, that calls for a big push towards infrastructure. Given how large we are as a country not only in terms

of building sports centres and that will inevitably arouse interest from many quarters. It is not necessary to build those fancy colossal stadiums. Once you create the infrastructure, the multiplier effect will kick in quickly. Talent will find an outlet and that means more people coming into the system. Ultimately, it is a story about scale and if the basics are firmly in place, the rest of the

minister who is passionate about it and who keeps the federations on their toes.

Is there a way to incentivise training structures for women in sports? Most certainly yes and we must have training programmes for women coaches. The time was always right to tap the great potential in India's women. We ought to have done a lot more

but just making a few right moves at this stage too will be a big positive. It's not too late.

If sports starts to spread in Jammu and Kashmir or in the Northeast, the scope and scale will start to look very different. There are many young men and women there and they are waiting for that one breakthrough moment. The sense of pride to represent India is there and we must continuously build on that.

Will India become a sports power in the next five years? It is not easy to answer that question since priorities take time to change. We are in a position today to think big and that will

of population but also real GDP, that cost of infrastructure can be addressed easily. In fact, it will become less of a burden but it needs that big push from the government. I would like to see them give tax incentives to building sports infrastructure and it is something I spoke of at least two decades ago. There are multiple ways to do this. One could incentivise the process

jigsaw puzzle falls into place—albeit not without effort but it may not be that hard either.

I wrote many, many years ago about the federations and the people that run them. There is the odd bit of good news that comes in from time to time but most of it is sordid. If the government is keen on developing sports, they need to do it like they have highways, with a

depend greatly on doing many right things. One thing I am very sure of is the ambition existing and that can only get larger. As I see it, we are at the start of a movement towards more medals and that is hugely encouraging. **BT**

As told to Krishna Gopalan. The author is a cricket commentator. Views are personal

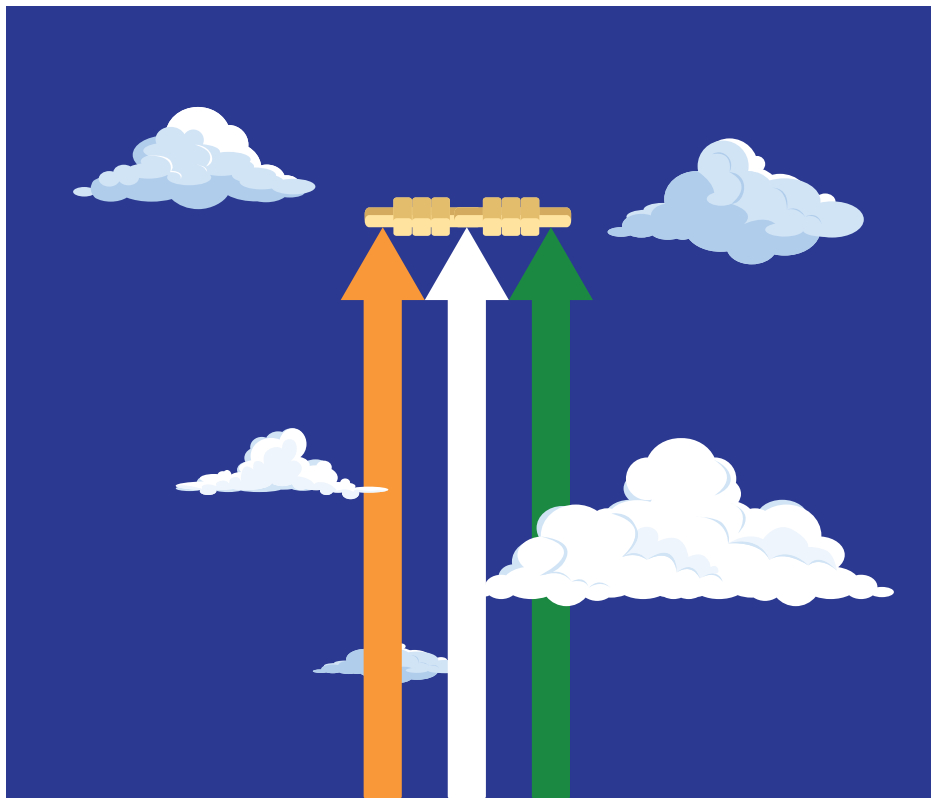


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